
Figure 4: The VNC console displaying the Linux desktop


Figure 5: Interacting with the VM and Hypervisor over chat


Figure 6: Monitoring Health through the Hypervisor

To get started on configuring a machine, you can set up various parameters related to the memory, the number of CPUs, etc, from the definition tab at the top. You will also have to create a new hard disk for the machine from the *Disks* tab at the top. Archipel supports qcow2, qcow, cow and raw formats for this. This hard disk now also needs to be added in the *Definition->Virtual Medias* tab. You might also want to add virtual network interfaces in the *Definition-> Virtual Nics* tab. After everything is set up, just copy the ISO of the OS you want to install into the */vm/iso* directory and change the boot device to *cdrom* after adding the path to the ISO in the *Definition-> Virtual Medias* tab, just like you added the hard disk before. You are now good to go, and ready to press that big 'Run' button at the top of the screen. Hopefully, you'll be able to see your machine booting up in the VNC console if everything goes well (Figure 4). Don't forget to *chat* up with your machine from the Chat tab (Figure 5). Ask it, "How are you?" and it will reply with a status report on what it is doing along with some statistics. To check out what more you can do, type in 'Help' and you will be shown a list of possible commands. The amazing graph visualisations on the statistics of the machines can be viewed from the *Health* tab of your Hypervisor (Figure 6). You can also see logs for all the machines under this tab when you click the *Logs* button.

Appliances, VMCasts, groups and more...

Archipel has a lot more to it than just its good looks. It even provides advanced management tools like VMCasts and Appliances, which allow you to subscribe to a feed of VMs like an RSS feed that is published from the XMPP server. It uses the XVM2 template format for this purpose. Another great aspect of Archipel is the awesome permissions system, which goes in-depth when granting permissions and allows you to create groups of contacts/VMs logically—assigning roles to each user that are related to what they can do in each machine. The lack of this feature often proves to be a deal breaker in many enterprise environments. Apart from this, it also supports industry standard features like cloning, scheduling actions, snapshots, live migration, etc. You can check out the Archipel wiki for details related to how you can go about using each feature.

The verdict

Frankly, everyone who hears about Archipel for the first time and the kind of features it provides will be impressed. It is quite easy to set up, use and manage. I'm not sure about how mature the code might be and the kind of bugs that may appear, but it is definitely worth giving a try. The team of developers is very supportive, though there is no commercial support available as of yet (the website does mention that it is "Coming soon"). But, if you deploy it in production, you're on your own. Above all that, it is a great choice for virtualisation in enterprise environments where remote access for VMs is crucial and when you need to manage thousands of VMs. What's more, with the project being developed on top of libvirt, you can expect some cross-hypervisor goodness too. END

Links

[1] Setting up eJabberd-*https://github.com/primalmotion/Archipel/wiki/Ejabberd%3A-Preparing-Ejabberd-%28Debian-Like%29*
[2] Archipel Wiki-*https://github.com/primalmotion/archipel/wiki*
[3] Ejabberd-*http://www.ejabberd.im/*

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The author has a crush on Java, and also loves flirting with almost anything related to databases, cloud computing and Web technologies. Feel free to comment on this article, and direct your feedback to *ankitreloaded@gmail.com*.